



CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

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2026 • SET B



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UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE
CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS CONTEST
SET B • SPRING 2026

1. The U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention stopped airing its "_____" ads, ending a 13-year campaign that helped millions of Americans quit smoking. The campaign featured real people sharing the devastating health effects of smoking and pointed viewers to free resources.

A. Truth Initiative	C. Tips from Former Smokers
B. Freedom from Smoking	D. Be Smart, Don't Start

2. General Yifat Tomer-Yerushalmi was the Israeli army's top lawyer until she was arrested after a bizarre sequence of events that included her abrupt resignation, a brief disappearance, and a frantic search. The saga began after she admitted to approving the leak of a surveillance video showing _____.

A. emergency workers being targeted after an explosion at a Palestinian hospital
B. an assault by Israeli soldiers against a Palestinian at a military prison
C. the Defense Minister accepting money from a defense contractor
D. the Prime Minister discussing delaying a hostage deal to allow for territorial gains

3. A report on book bans in U.S. schools found _____ as the author most likely to be censored. PEN America's "Banned in the USA" study found the author's books were censored 206 times, during the 2024-2025 school year, with 87 of their works affected.

A. Stephen King	C. Toni Morrison
B. Mark Twain	D. Kurt Vonnegut

4. What is thought to be the world's largest-known spiderweb was discovered in a cave on the Albanian-Greek border. The most surprising thing about the spider colony, with an estimated 110,000 spiders, was that _____. The stunning behavior had never been observed before.

A. they were surviving on eating only other spiders
B. over half of the spiders had become effectively sightless
C. the spiders could survive without any sunlight
D. two different spider species were living together peacefully

5. In November, _____ announced plans to revoke 17,000 commercial driver's licenses after discovering the expiration dates went past when the drivers were legally allowed to be in the country. The announcement followed criticism from the Trump administration about illegal drivers; however, the governor's office stated all drivers held valid federal work authorizations.
- A. California
B. Texas
C. Florida
D. New York
6. Laurent Freixe, the CEO of the Swiss food giant _____, was abruptly dismissed for failing to disclose a romantic relationship with a subordinate. He became CEO exactly one year before his removal.
- A. Unilever
B. Lindt
C. Lorenz
D. Nestlé
7. The nation's top drug regulator, Richard Pazdur, decided to retire three weeks after taking the job. According to reports, Pazdur raised concerns about the legality and pace of agency plans to expedite drug decisions. Pazdur's retirement followed tensions with FDA Commissioner _____, who has touted multiple initiatives aimed at boosting the agency's efficiency.
- A. Howard Lutnick
B. Sean Duffy
C. Marty Makary
D. John Ratcliffe
8. Vaccine advisers to the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention voted to abandon universal _____ vaccination for newborns, instead recommending individual decision-making in consultation with a healthcare provider for mothers who test negative for the virus.
- A. respiratory syncytial virus (RSV)
B. rota virus
C. whooping cough
D. hepatitis B
9. Venezuelan opposition leader _____ appeared in public for the first time in 11 months after a daring escape from her homeland when she emerged from a hotel balcony in Oslo, Norway. Her appearance came hours after her daughter accepted the Nobel Peace Prize award on her behalf.
- A. Giorgia Meloni
B. Claudia Sheinbaum
C. María Corina Machado
D. Dina Boluarte

10. In a tense meeting at the White House in October, President Trump urged Ukrainian President Zelensky to concede the entire _____ region to Russia to clinch a deal, according to people familiar with the exchange. The change in approach came just days after Trump's statements that he was considering giving Ukraine access to long-range Tomahawk missiles to strike Russia.
- A. Carpathian
B. Donbas
C. Odesa
D. Crimean
11. President Trump stated that Somalia "stinks and we don't want them in our country. We could go one way or the other, and we're going to go the wrong way if we keep taking in garbage into our country." These statements came after he announced an ICE operation targeting Somalis in _____ and terminating temporary legal protections for the immigrant community there.
- A. Illinois
B. Minnesota
C. New York
D. New Jersey
12. _____ responded to FCC Chair Brendan Carr's comments about Jimmy Kimmel by saying, "I hate what Jimmy Kimmel said," but likened Carr's comments about Disney taking the easy way or the hard way to a classic mob movie. "That's right out of a mafioso coming into a bar going, 'nice bar you have here, it'd be a shame if something happened to it.'"
- A. Chuck Schumer
B. John Thune
C. Ted Cruz
D. Hakeem Jefferies
13. Pope Leo XIV declared 15-year-old Carlo Acutis the first _____ saint at an open-air Mass in the Vatican's St. Peter's Square. Informally known as "God's influencer," Acutis was just 15 when he died of acute promyelocytic leukemia.
- A. U.S.
B. millennial
C. Honduran
D. teenage
14. Researchers from the University of Florida and the Texas Department of State Health Services argued that _____, a parasitic condition transmitted by the bloodsucking "kissing bug," has a high enough presence in the U.S. to be considered endemic, a regularly occurring disease.
- A. malaria
B. Chagas disease
C. babesiosis
D. amebiasis

15. The sight of a massive "Rising Dragon" fireworks display exploding in the _____ sparked a furious environmental backlash, prompting a local government investigation and forcing global outdoor apparel brand Arc'teryx to issue an apology.
- A. Arctic Circle
B. Great Barrier Reef
C. Himalayas
D. Amazon Rainforest
16. _____ has agreed not to contest claims that its Ohio facility violated the Clean Water Act more than 5,400 times over a 6 and a half-year period, leading to pollution in a river that feeds Lake Erie.
- A. Mattel
B. Campbell's Soup
C. Goodyear
D. Procter & Gamble
17. _____ Defense Ministry said on September 28th that it had again observed drones at several of its armed forces' locations a day after the NATO alliance announced that it would enhance its vigilance in the Baltic Sea region. This was the latest unexplained drone activity after sightings over five airports caused closures in the country the week prior.
- A. Estonia's
B. Finland's
C. Denmark's
D. Poland's
18. A federal judge ruled that a nearly complete offshore wind project halted by the administration could resume. Work on the nearly completed Revolution Wind project for _____ had been paused for over a month after the Bureau of Ocean Energy Management issued a stop work order for what it said were national security concerns.
- A. New York and New Jersey
B. California and Oregon
C. Virginia and Maryland
D. Rhode Island and Connecticut
19. The U.S. Department of Energy said that it will loan \$1 billion to help finance the restart of the nuclear power plant at Pennsylvania's _____, which is under contract to supply power to data centers for tech giant Microsoft. The plant was the site of the nation's worst commercial nuclear power accident in 1979.
- A. Palo Verde Park
B. Love Canal
C. Hope Creek
D. Three Mile Island

20. _____ filed a software recall with the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration related to how its self-driving cars respond to stopped school buses. In an Austin ISD video, a driverless vehicle could be seen driving through a stop. After the violation, the school district asked the company to cease operations around student pickup and drop-off times.
- A. Waymo
B. Tesla
C. Uber
D. AutoX
21. Worldwide solar and wind power generation outpaced the growth in electricity demand in 2025, and for the first time on record, renewable energies combined generated more power than _____.
- A. nuclear reactors
B. hydroelectric
C. coal
D. natural gas
22. A UN commission of inquiry released a report stating there were reasonable grounds to conclude that four of the five genocidal acts defined under international law have been carried out by _____ since 2023. The foreign ministry of the accused country said it categorically rejected the report, denouncing it as “distorted and false.”
- A. Russia
B. Sudan
C. the United States
D. Israel
23. A vigil started in 1981 by activist William Thomas to promote nuclear disarmament and an end to global conflicts that was believed to be the longest continuous anti-war protest in U.S. history was taken down outside the _____ as part of the clearing of homeless encampments in the nation’s capital.
- A. Supreme Court
B. Lincoln Memorial
C. Pentagon
D. White House
24. The scaffolding set up along the western side of the _____ for conservation work about 20 years ago was removed, allowing an uncluttered view of the UNESCO World Heritage site before the next round of conservation begins. Culture Minister Lina Mendoni noted it marked the first time in about 200 years that the site's exterior is completely free of any kind of scaffolding.
- A. Angkor Wat
B. Parthenon
C. Great Sphinx
D. Taj Mahal

25. _____ announced that intense solar radiation may corrupt data critical to flight controls on a “significant number” of its most popular aircraft. The fixes led to delays and cancellations around the world and American Airlines described its response as “all hands on deck” as it identified hundreds of planes that required software updates.
- A. General Dynamics
B. Airbus
C. Boeing
D. Lockheed Martin
26. UNICEF released analysis of data from more than 190 countries between 2000 and 2022 that found one in 10 school-aged children is _____. That marks the first time there are more children in the world under that designation than there are considered undernourished.
- A. obese
B. impoverished
C. unsheltered
D. orphaned
27. Television host _____ apologized for making the on-air statement that people who are experiencing homelessness and mental illnesses should be executed. The apology came amid a climate where people across the U.S. were fired or disciplined at their jobs for offensive political comments.
- A. Pat McAfee
B. Brian Kilmeade
C. Stephen Colbert
D. Matthew Dowd
28. About 2,500 _____ police and soldiers launched a massive raid on a drug-trafficking gang in late October, arresting 81 suspects and sparking shootouts that left at least 60 suspects and four police officers dead. The operation included officers in helicopters and armored vehicles, and targeted the notorious Red Command in the sprawling low-income area.
- A. Venezuelan
B. Mexican
C. Brazilian
D. Colombian
29. _____ shares tripled the day after the U.S. government took a 10% stake in the company exploring Alaska for copper and other metals. The deal came along with the reversal of a decision that previously stopped the Ambler Road Project from going forward. It’s a proposed 211-mile road to enable access to large deposits of copper, cobalt, gallium, and germanium.
- A. NiCorp Developments
B. MP Materials
C. Trilogy Metals
D. Osisko Development

30. President Trump signed an executive order to provide _____ a U.S. security guarantee with conditions similar to NATO's Article 5. The rare upgraded security guarantee is part of the "compensation" for the failed Israeli strike against Hamas officials in the nation's capital.
- A. Saudi Arabia
B. Lebanon
- C. Jordan
D. Qatar
31. " _____ " is the Cambridge Dictionary's Word of the Year for 2025. Chief editor Colin McIntosh said, "It was originally coined as an academic word and was confined to the academic sphere for quite a long time. It's only fairly recently that it's made a shift into popular language and it's one of those words that have been influenced by social media."
- A. Brain rot
B. Parasocial
- C. Rage bait
D. Biohack
32. The Trump administration is weighing whether to relocate the Federal Emergency Management Agency to _____ and tap the state's top emergency official, Nim Kidd, to lead it. Kidd sits on a 13-member FEMA review council. Politico reported that the panel is expected to recommend FEMA's move.
- A. Texas
B. Florida
- C. Virginia
D. South Carolina
33. The first of 30 Bob Ross paintings have been auctioned off to support _____. More than 400 half-hour episodes of his show, *The Joy of Painting*, aired from 1983 to 1994, the year before Ross died of cancer. His show, which still airs and streams, has surged in popularity in recent years, but his artwork rarely goes up for sale.
- A. the Audubon Society
B. PBS
- C. the Smithsonian
D. NPR
34. The conservative news network _____ filed an antitrust lawsuit against Fox News, saying Fox sought to maintain its market dominance through intimidation and exclusionary business practices such as pressuring guests not to appear on the rival network.
- A. Breitbart
B. Newsmax
- C. Daily Caller
D. One America News Network

35. Companies that want to hire employees from other countries using the popular H-1B visa program now have to pay _____ per worker. The new fee will drastically change the math for businesses that consider using the program, but it will cost less than the originally announced annual fee for the same amount.
- A. \$100,000
B. \$10,000
C. \$1,000,000
D. \$1,000
36. The nomination of _____ to lead the Bureau of Labor Statistics was withdrawn. As the chief economist at The Heritage Foundation, the nominee was a major critic of the BLS. Yet most economists saw them as overtly partisan and warned that misreads on economic measures made them a risk to lead the federal agency.
- A. Erika McEntarfer
B. Susie Wiles
C. E.J. Antoni
D. William J. Wiatrowski
37. Images of the U.S. Treasury Secretary's phone were reported to show a text regarding the situation in _____ and the administration's plan to offer a \$20 billion lifeline to the nation's central bank. The country temporarily rolled back its export tax allowing China to buy soybeans. China was the largest buyer of U.S. soybeans, but had not purchased any since May.
- A. Argentina
B. Honduras
C. Chile
D. Brazil
38. Which of the following was **NOT** part of an amendment approved for the Texas Constitution by voters in November?
- A. developing a Border Integrity Fund for funding border-crossing impediments
B. creating an endowment for the Texas State Technical College Program
C. allocating up to \$1 billion of sales tax revenue into the Texas Water Fund each year
D. providing \$3 billion to create the Dementia Prevention and Research Institute of Texas
39. President Donald Trump said that he had signed a commutation that would immediately release former Representative _____ from prison. In April, the former member of Congress was sentenced to more than seven years in prison. In 2024, he pleaded guilty to charges of committing wire fraud and aggravated identity theft.
- A. Brian Kelsey
B. Michael Grimm
C. Henry Cuellar
D. George Santos

40. Paramount attempted a hostile bid to acquire Warner Bros. Discovery after it lost to Netflix in a high-stakes bidding war. Paramount said it would offer \$30 per share for the entire media conglomerate. Netflix previously agreed to buy part of Warner Bros. Discovery's studio and streaming assets for \$27.75 per share. Paramount's CEO is ____.
- | | |
|------------------|-------------------|
| A. David Ellison | C. Ted Sarandos |
| B. David Zaslav | D. Shari Redstone |

ESSAY PROMPT:

NOTE: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The rankings of essays will be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed. A focused, concise and specific essay beats a vague and rambling essay. Proper grammar and organization should be used to aid clarity, but should not be considered a major factor in scoring. Cover as many corners of the issue as practical. Avoid including personal editorialized opinions, as more than enough information on the subject has been published.

*“Russia remains a threat today, tomorrow and in the foreseeable future for the whole of Europe”
Finnish prime minister Petteri Orpo said at a press conference.*

Citing Russia's “increasing... hybrid operations and acts of sabotage against Europe”, the leaders of the eight NATO nations said: “Russia is the most significant, direct and long-term threat to our security and to peace and stability in the Euro-Atlantic area”.

The statement reads: “Russia's strategic goals remain unchanged: to create a buffer zone stretching from the Arctic region through the Baltic and Black Seas to the Mediterranean.

The Eastern Flank of the European Union and NATO is at the forefront of this threat, but the threat affects the entire European continent, calling for urgent and coordinated action.”

-Perkin Amalaraj reporting for The Daily Mail, Dec. 16, 2025

The war in Ukraine emerged as a central focus for European powers seeking a peace that not only supports Ukraine, but also looks to prevent future Russian aggression against other parts of Europe. Discuss the issues, events, and relations that have shaped the European response to the conflict and their approach to collective security moving forward.

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ANSWER KEY

(2 points each)

1. C
2. B
3. A
4. D
5. A
6. D
7. C
8. D
9. C
10. B
11. B
12. C
13. B
14. B
15. C
16. B
17. C
18. D
19. D
20. A

21. C
22. D
23. D
24. B
25. B
26. A
27. B
28. C
29. C
30. D
31. B
32. A
33. B
34. B
35. A
36. C
37. A
38. A
39. D
40. A

Points contestants could mention in their essay:

Background

•The Russian invasion of Ukraine began in early 2022 and Russian military controls approximately 20% of the country after slow gains.

•Russia has been blamed for several instances of hybrid warfare in Europe including airspace violations by both drones and military jets in Poland, Estonia, and over airports in Denmark that led to temporary closures. Rail lines have been damaged in Poland, flights have had their GPS systems jammed in the Baltic countries, and drone swarms have been reported in Germany over sensitive sites. Russian ally Belarus has been blamed for balloon intrusions into Lithuania. These events have been characterized as probing weaknesses and response efforts.

•President Trump called for 5% of GDP be spent by NATO members. EU expenditures surged to ~\$400 billion for 2025. There has been a shift from a US to Europe-centric strategy.

•Divisions amongst countries exist with Hungary supporting “peace” by opposing Ukrainian aide/Russian sanctions, and Slovakia & Czechia against new loans. Some countries support a truce rather than insisting on a finalized peace agreement.

U.S. relations

•Poland and others that border Russia fear the US will not consider a post-war situation that appeases Putin with territorial concessions. The US has discussed creating a “free economic zone” in the Donbas which raises administration questions

Ukrainian relations

•The EU has supplied approximately \$200 billion in

aid to Ukraine since the conflict began and has been resolute in supporting President Zelensky, but a scandal surrounding the embezzlement of millions from the state energy program has led to criticism & doubts.

•Ukraine applied for EU membership after Russia invaded in 2022. Russia appears open to Ukraine in the EU, but has steadfastly rejected their NATO membership. The US has discussed NATO-like Article Five security guarantees for Ukraine which most of Europe supports.

•The creation of a multinational “Coalition of the Willing” has been discussed by 30 nations. Germany began its first permanent foreign deployment of troops since WWII to Lithuania, has expanded the size of its military, and is considering conscription. In January, a post-ceasefire force was announced that would secure Ukraine and be backed by the US in case of Russian attack.

Russian relations

•An International Claims Commission for Ukraine was created to compensate Ukraine for war damages caused by Russia using their assets. Belgium controls most of the over \$200 billion in frozen assets, but fears Russian retaliation for accessing the funds further. A \$105 billion traditional loan from the EU was announced in mid-Dec.

•The REPowerEU Plan is seeking to end reliance on Russian energy by reducing imports and creating alternative renewable sources within the EU. Oil imports from Russia have dropped and 2028 is the goal to end natural gas imports.